

Birth control: Breaking the myth

There are many common myths surrounding the use of birth control—especially oral contraceptives. These myths often create fear and confusion for women who may benefit from using them. Let's break down some of the most common misconceptions and clarify the facts.

Myth #1: Birth control causes permanent infertility

One of the most widespread myths is that taking birth control will prevent a woman from being able to have children in the future. This is not true.

Birth control pills contain synthetic versions of the hormones estrogen and progesterone, which naturally occur in a woman's body. These hormones work together to regulate the menstrual cycle and prevent ovulation while the pill is being taken. However, once birth control is stopped, hormone levels typically return to their natural patterns, and ovulation resumes—often within weeks or a few months.

For most women, fertility returns to their normal baseline after discontinuing birth control. If a woman was able to conceive before using birth control, she is generally able to do so afterward, assuming there are no other underlying health conditions.

Myth #2: Birth control always causes excessive weight gain

Another common belief is that birth control inevitably leads to significant weight gain. While some women may experience mild weight changes, this is not universal.

- Certain formulations—particularly older, higher-dose pills or specific hormonal methods—may cause fluid retention or increased appetite.
- Many modern low-dose pills have minimal impact on weight.
- If weight gain does occur, switching to a different formulation can often resolve the issue.

Not all birth control methods affect the body in the same way, and there are many options available.

Myth #3: Birth control is only for preventing pregnancy

While pregnancy prevention is a primary function, birth control has several additional medical benefits. Because it helps regulate estrogen and progesterone levels, it can improve symptoms related to hormonal imbalance.

Birth control is commonly prescribed to help with:

- Heavy or prolonged periods
- Painful menstrual cramps

- Irregular cycles
- Acne
- Excess facial hair (such as hair under the chin or around the jaw)
- Hormone-related mood fluctuations

For many women, birth control helps restore hormonal balance and significantly improves quality of life.

What if someone is concerned about hormones?

For women who prefer to avoid additional hormones, non-hormonal options are available, including:

- Copper IUDs
- Diaphragms (fitted to the cervix)
- Condoms

These methods prevent pregnancy without introducing hormones into the body.

The Bottom Line

Birth control does not cause permanent infertility. Once discontinued, the body returns to its natural hormonal rhythm, allowing pregnancy if no other fertility issues exist.

Additionally, birth control is not solely about preventing pregnancy. It is a valuable medical tool used to regulate hormones, manage painful or heavy periods, treat acne, and address other hormone-related symptoms.

Every woman's body is different. The best approach is to discuss options with a healthcare provider to determine which method aligns with personal health goals, comfort level, and lifestyle.